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# Balancing Standardization and Adaptation in Nordic B2B Service Companies

## A Qualitative Study of International Marketing Strategies Across Markets

Halmstad, May 18, 2026
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# Abstract

**Title**: Balancing Standardization and Adaptation in Nordic B2B Service Companies

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This study explores how Nordic B2B service companies balance standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across multiple markets, and which organizational and contextual factors influence this balance in practice. As companies increasingly operate across international markets, they face growing challenges related to maintaining strategic consistency while simultaneously responding to local market conditions.

The study applies a qualitative research design based on semi-structured interviews with seven respondents from five Nordic B2B service companies operating across multiple markets. The respondents held positions within marketing, strategy and business development. The empirical material was analyzed through thematic analysis based on an analytical framework consisting of strategic orientation, drivers shaping the balance between standardization and adaptation, and coordination and implementation across markets.

The findings show that the studied companies apply hybrid approaches where strategic core elements, such as brand identity and value proposition, are largely standardized, while executional marketing activities and customer-facing communication are adapted to local market conditions. Furthermore, the findings indicate that this balance is shaped by both external factors, including regulation, market maturity and customer expectations, and internal organizational factors such as resource availability, organizational structure and coordination capabilities. The findings also highlight the importance of coordination between headquarters and local units in managing consistency and local responsiveness across markets.

The findings indicate that balancing standardization and adaptation is not a fixed strategic decision, but an ongoing process shaped by organizational conditions, coordination and changing market demands.

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# 1 Introduction

## 1.1 Background

Globalization has led many Nordic companies to expand beyond their domestic markets in order to reach new customers and strengthen their competitive position. As companies increasingly operate across multiple markets, they must navigate varying cultural, institutional, and market-related conditions. This development has increased the complexity of international marketing, requiring companies to carefully design and implement strategies that balance global consistency with local market relevance across markets.

This challenge is particularly relevant for B2B service companies, which often operate across multiple markets while relying on long-term customer relationships and coordinated market communication.

A central assumption within the international marketing research is that a company's international marketing strategy influences its performance across markets. However, there remains considerable debate regarding how international marketing strategy should be defined and conceptualized. Zou and Cavusgil (2002) argue that international marketing strategy consists of several interconnected dimensions, including standardization, coordination, and integration across markets. At the same time, they highlight that the lack of conceptual clarity within the literature has made it difficult to fully understand how different strategic approaches influence company performance.

Integrating marketing communications (IMC) has emerged as an important mechanism for coordinating marketing activities across channels and national markets. By aligning messaging and branding, companies can create a more consistent market presence across different contexts (Batra & Keller, 2016). In B2B settings, where long-term relationships and customer trust are central, multinational corporations must also manage customer interactions across regions while remaining responsive to local market conditions (Lee & Griffith, 2019).

This creates a strategic tension between standardization and adaptation in international marketing strategy. Standardization refers to the use of consistent marketing practices across markets, while adaptation involves adjusting marketing activities to local preferences and conditions (Szymanski et al., 1993). Previous research suggest that the effectiveness of international marketing strategies depends on how companies balance global consistency with local responsiveness (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002; Lee & Griffith, 2019).

## 1.2 Problem Discussion

The debate surrounding standardization versus adaptation remains central within international marketing research, particularly for B2B companies operating across multiple markets. As companies expand internationally, they must develop marketing strategies that support global strategic consistency while remaining responsive to local market conditions. (Lee & Griffith, 2019)

Finding the appropriate balance between efficiency and market responsiveness represents a central challenge in international marketing strategy.

Previous research indicates that standardized marketing strategies can strengthen brand consistency and create scale efficiencies, while also risking reduced sensitivity to cultural and contextual market differences. In contrast, adaptation emphasizes the importance of tailoring marketing activities to local needs and conditions, which has been associated with increased market relevance and competitiveness (Rao-Nicholson & Khan, 2017). By responding to differences in customer expectations, regulatory environments, and competitive conditions, companies may strengthen their local market position (Rashkova et al., 2024). This creates a strategic tension regarding how companies can balance global consistency with local responsiveness across markets.

Firms' decisions regarding standardization and adaptation are often shaped by a combination of external and internal factors. Rao-Nicholson & Khan (2017) argue that institutional pressures within host markets, together with organizational conditions, influence how companies structure their international marketing strategies

External factors such as regulatory frameworks, cultural norms and competitive conditions shape the strategic environment in which companies operate. Significant institutional differences may require greater local adaptation to achieve market legitimacy, whereas more similar market conditions can support standardized approaches that enable scale efficiencies and strategic consistency (Szymanski et al., 1993).

Internal organizational conditions also influence the extent to which companies are able to standardize or adapt their marketing strategies. Factors such as resource availability, organizational structure, and strategic capabilities affect how companies respond to varying market conditions. Rao-Nicholson and Khan (2017) argue that organizational characteristics shape companies' strategic responses to institutional pressures across markets. This highlights the importance of considering both institutional and organizational conditions when examining international marketing strategy.

Rather than viewing standardization and adaptation as mutually exclusive strategies, recent research suggests that combining elements of both approaches may represent a more effective strategic solution across different market contexts (Vrontis, 2009; Rashkova et al., 2024).

Despite extensive research on standardization and adaptation, existing literature often treats this balance as a strategic orientation rather than an ongoing organizational process. As a result, there is still limited understanding of how companies practically

coordinate and manage standardized and locally adapted marketing activities across multiple markets. In particular, there is a lack of empirical research examining how Nordic B2B service companies balance these approaches across multiple markets and how internal organizational conditions influence this process. Furthermore, much of the existing literature has focused on multinational corporations, consumer markets or conceptual discussions of standardization and adaptation. Consequently, there remains limited empirical understanding of how these dynamics are managed in practice within Nordic B2B service companies, where relationship-based value creation, coordination and organizational capabilities play a central role.

## 1.3 Purpose

The purpose of this thesis is to explore how Nordic B2B service companies balance standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across multiple markets, and to identify the strategic, organizational and contextual factors that shape this balance, as well as how it is managed and implemented in practice.

## 1.4 Research Question

The main research question for this study is:

How do Nordic B2B service companies balance standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across multiple markets?

To address this question, the study is guided by the following sub-questions:

- How do Nordic B2B companies approach the balance between standardization and adaptation in their marketing strategies across different markets?
- To what extent and in which ways do internal and external factors affect the balance between standardization and adaptation?
- How are standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies coordinated and managed across headquarters and local units?

## 1.5 Delimitations

The study is limited to Nordic B2B service companies operating across multiple international markets. Furthermore, the study adopts a firm-level strategic perspective and does not include consumer-based data. The focus is therefore placed on organizational and strategic decision-making processes rather than customer perceptions or market outcomes. These delimitations enable a focused analysis of how firms balance standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across markets.

# 2 Theoretical Framework

The theoretical framework will be based on previous research within international marketing strategy, with focus on the strategic balance between standardization and adaptation, the underlying drivers shaping these strategic choices as well as the organizational alignment of marketing strategies across different markets. Together, these theories provide a foundation for analyzing how Nordic B2B service companies design, manage and implement marketing strategies across multiple markets.

## 2.1 Conceptual Foundations

This chapter highlights the key concepts that provide a strong foundation for the theoretical framework. In the context of this study, international marketing strategy refers to the coordinated management of marketing elements across multiple markets (Katsikeas et al., 2020; Zou & Cavusgil, 2002). Another key part to this perspective is the tension between standardization and adaptation, which refers to the degree to which elements within marketing strategies are standardized or adapted across markets (Szymanski et al., 1993; Vrontis, 2003).

Furthermore, in this study, strategic coordination refers to the organizational and decision-making processes through which marketing strategies are coordinated and structured across headquarters and local units, ensuring consistency in strategic direction while allowing for local adaptation (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002; Batra & Keller, 2016).

## 2.2 International Marketing

While international marketing strategy is generally understood as the coordinated management of marketing activities across multiple markets, prior research suggests that it reflects a multidimensional and dynamic strategic approach rather than a simple choice between global standardization and adaptation.

Zou and Cavusgil (2002) present a framework for global marketing strategy (GMS), describing it as a set of strategic decisions concerning standardization, coordination of marketing activities, and global market participation. Rather than reducing strategy to a simple choice between global standardization and adaptation, their framework highlights that firms make decisions regarding product offerings, communication, pricing and distribution at the same time, while coordinating these activities across markets. This perspective emphasizes that performance depends on the degree to which strategic approach aligns with external conditions and organizational capabilities.

Extending this perspective, Katsikeas et al. (2020) argue that international marketing strategy effectiveness is not only shaped by a strategic approach, but also on how it is implemented and supported within the organization. Their framework highlights the

interaction between external market conditions, internal capabilities, and managerial decision-making. In this context, international marketing strategy does not only concern decision-making but also how these decisions are implemented and maintained across multiple markets. This perspective emphasizes the organizational aspects of strategy, showing that it requires appropriate coordination structures and internal capabilities to function effectively.

In a more recent contribution, Solberg and Durrieu (2023) identify clear patterns of international marketing strategy, demonstrating that firms adopt different strategic approaches depending on their degree of global integration and local adaptation. Their findings suggest that international marketing strategy evolves over time as firms expand and adjust their strategic approaches across markets. Rather than representing a fixed strategic choice, international marketing strategy reflects an ongoing process of adjustment shaped by competitive pressures, institutional environments and internal capabilities.

Together, these perspectives define international marketing strategy as a multidimensional and dynamic concept that includes strategic decision-making, organizational coordination, and adaptation to market conditions. In the context of Nordic B2B service firms, this theoretical foundation provides a basis for analyzing how firms structure their international marketing strategies, how decisions are coordinated across markets, and how the balance between standardization and adaptation is managed in practice.

## 2.3 Standardization vs. Adaptation

### 2.3.1 Drivers of Standardization and Adaptation

To understand why companies choose a standardized or adaptive strategic approach, it is important to recognize that this choice is shaped by a combination of external and internal factors rather than being a purely strategic preference.

Rao-Nicholson and Khan (2017) argue that firms' decisions are influenced by both institutional pressures in host markets and organizational contexts within the firm. Their institutional and organizational perspective suggests that companies must assess the degree of similarity or difference across markets when determining how far marketing strategies can be standardized.

On the external level, institutional differences across markets such as regulatory frameworks, industry standards, cultural norms and competitive structures, shape the strategic environment in which companies operate. These variations influence how companies' position, communicate, and coordinate their marketing activities across multiple markets. When institutional environments vary significantly, firms may need to adapt their marketing strategies in order to achieve legitimacy and alignment with local stakeholders. In contrast, when markets share similar institutional and competitive conditions, standardization may be viable and strategically beneficial, allowing firms to leverage scale efficiencies and maintain a coherent strategic position (Szymanski et al., 1993).

In addition to external pressures, internal organizational conditions play a central role in shaping companies' strategic responses to different markets. Organizational structure, resource availability, strategic orientation, and international experience shape the extent to which companies are able and willing to implement standardized or adaptive strategies across markets (Rao-Nicholson & Khan, 2017). In addition to structural and resource factors, companies' internal strategic priorities also influence their orientation toward standardization or adaptation. Aguinis and Burgi-Tian (2023) argue that organizations differ in how they balance consistency and flexibility in their strategic objectives and evaluation practices. Firms that prioritize consistent objectives across markets are more likely to pursue standardized approaches, while organizations that emphasize contextual responsiveness may adopt more adaptive strategies. In this sense, internal performance priorities can act as underlying drivers shaping strategic choices across markets.

Taken together, these arguments suggest that the degree of standardization or adaptation in international marketing strategy is not determined by a single factor, but emerges from the interaction between institutional environments, markets similarities and differences, and internal organizational priorities. Strategic choices therefore reflect a context-dependent assessment of both external pressures and firm-level capabilities. In the context of Nordic B2B service firms, these drivers provide a foundation for examining how companies evaluate market conditions, interpret internal limitations, and determine the appropriate balance between standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across multiple markets.

### 2.3.2 Standardization and Adaptation as a dynamic process

While the previous section has identified the internal and external factors shaping firms' strategic decisions toward standardization or adaptation, the question remains how this balance is implemented in practice. Early research has often treated standardization and adaptation as alternative strategic outcomes, however, later contributions have increasingly challenged this either-or perspective. Demetris Vrontis (2003) introduced the AdaptStand modelling process (see Figure 1), arguing that firms should not necessarily choose between a fully standardized or adaptive approach. Instead, firms are encouraged to combine elements of both strategies, adjusting the balance according to internal and external conditions.

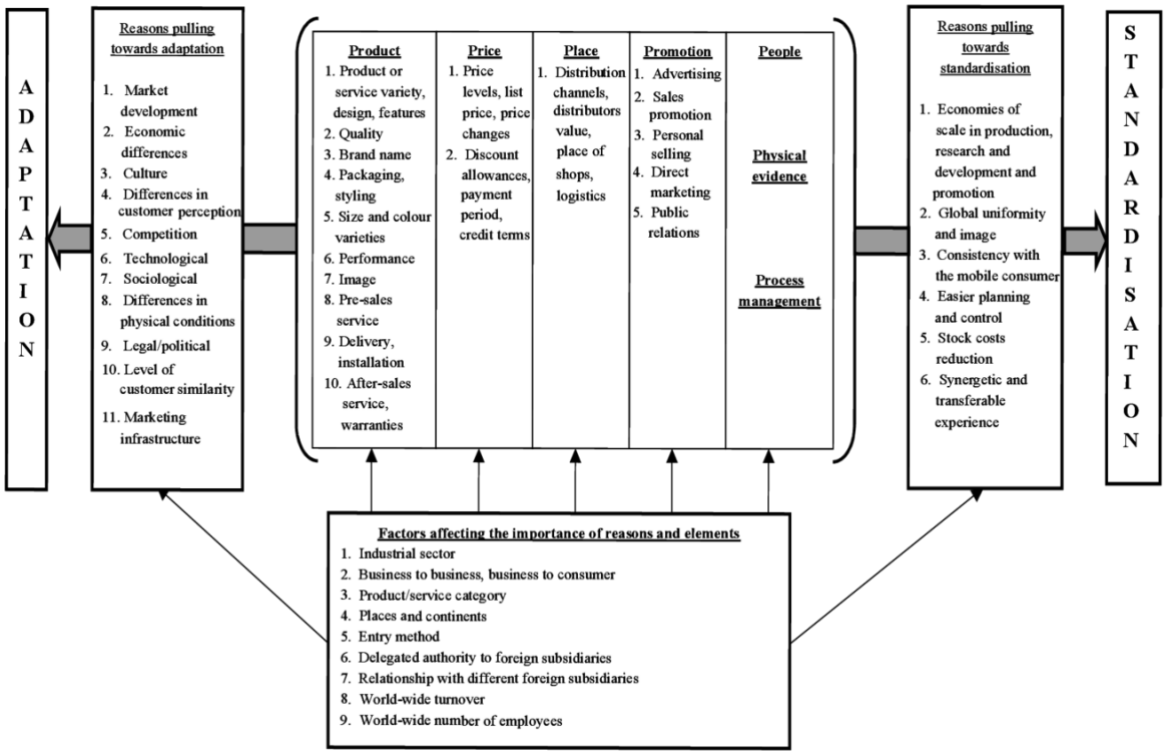



*Figure 1. The AdaptStand Modelling Process (Vrontis, 2003, p. 286).*

The model is further illustrated with the "Vrontris Triangular Pyramid of AdaptStand Integration", which provides a structured framework guiding multinational firms toward a combined marketing strategy that reflects both global consistency and local adaptation (Vrontis, 2003).

Building further on this research, Vrontis et al. (2009) highlight that firms should avoid a full either-or approach at all costs, as every market is different. Furthermore, it is important to distinguish the AdaptStand approach from glocalization. While glocalization refers to both strategic and tactical levels, the AdaptStand model specifically addresses firm's behavior at the tactical level, particularly in relation to how marketing decisions are implementation across markets. Finding this balance between standardization and adaptation is a challenging conundrum for multinational firms, and it is not a one-time strategic decision. It is an ongoing challenge that requires companies to balance global standardization and local adaptation while continuously adjusting their strategies in response to changing market conditions and organizational demands (Vrontis et al., 2009).

In a more recent study, the concept of standardization and adaptation as a co-constituted process is further strengthened by Poulis (2024), who argues that rather than representing two different strategic alternatives, standardization and adaptation are relationally shaped and continuously balanced across organizational levels and market contexts. In this sense, strategic outcomes are not determined in isolation but shaped through context-bound interactions among organizational actors, institutional environments and market conditions. This perspective shows that the balance between

standardization and adaptation is not fixed, but continuously managed and adjusted in response to shifts in competitive and contextual dynamics.

Poulis's (2024) framework is used to deepen the analysis of how Nordic B2B service companies manage and continuously negotiate the balance between standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies, building upon the foundation established by Vrontis (2003).

## 2.4 Marketing Strategy Alignment Across Markets

### 2.4.1 Strategic Core and Local Adaptation

Ensuring alignment across markets represents a central challenge in international marketing strategy. Integrated marketing communication (IMC) has been identified as a key mechanism for creating strategic coherence across markets (Batra & Keller, 2016). Rather than relying on full standardization, Batra and Keller (2016) argue that firms can establish a standardized strategic core, including elements such as brand positioning, value proposition, messaging and market priorities, while allowing local units to adapt executional elements to market-specific conditions.

In an international B2B context, this further extends to coordination between headquarters and local units regarding decision-making and implementation processes. Lee and Griffith (2019) argue that effective marketing strategy requires balancing global strategic orientation with local adaptation, not as separate alternatives but as interdependent processes.

### 2.4.2 Organizational Coordination Mechanisms

Moving further, while a standardized strategic core provides direction, alignment across markets depends on organizational coordination mechanisms governing decision-making authority and strategic integration across units (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002). Research shows that the degree of local initiative-taking influences how global strategies are implemented in practice (Ambos et al., 2010). This suggests that the balance between centralized control and local flexibility becomes a key aspect in understanding how marketing strategies are operationalized and implemented across markets. Further, Homburg et al. (1999) argue that marketing's influence within a company is not shaped by only market-related conditions but also by institutionalized organizational factors. This suggests that the role of marketing is contingent on both situational and internal organizational dynamics.

### 2.4.3 Contextual influences on Alignment

Coordination mechanisms are shaped by contextual differences across markets. Rao-Nicholson and Khan (2017) highlight that factors such as institutional environments, competitive intensity, and cross-market differences influence firms' strategic choices regarding standardization and adaptation. This suggests that the extent to which headquarters can achieve strategic coherence depends on the specific conditions of different markets contexts.

From a relational perspective, coordination across markets should not be understood as a static structural arrangement, but rather as a continuous and contextually embedded process (Poulis, 2024). Instead of reflecting a fixed balance between centralization and local flexibility, coordination is shaped through ongoing interactions between organizational actors and changing markets conditions.

Furthermore, different patterns of international marketing strategy reflect how firms' structure and manage their coordination mechanisms in response to varying contextual conditions (Solberg & Durrieu, 2023). This suggests that the degree of alignment is not universal but depends on both organizational structures and market-specific conditions.

Taken together, this literature suggests that marketing strategy alignment across markets is shaped through the interaction between a standardized strategic core, organizational coordination mechanisms, and contextual influences. Alignment is therefore not only a matter of strategic intent, but also of how decision-making authority, local flexibility, and market-specific conditions interact in practice. This perspective provides an analytical foundation for examining how Nordic B2B service firms coordinate marketing strategies across headquarters and local units while balancing centralized control with local adaptation across markets.

## 2.5 Summary and Analytical Framework

The reviewed literature shows that standardization and adaptation are not mutually exclusive strategic choices but rather should be viewed as a balance that is continuously managed across markets, organizational levels and implementation contexts.
Previous research highlights that this balance is shaped by both external market conditions and internal organizational factors, including institutional differences, market dynamics, coordination mechanisms, organizational capabilities and decision-making authority.
Furthermore, the research emphasizes that the balance between standardization and adaptation is not a one-time strategic choice, but an ongoing process, meaning that companies continuously adjust their strategic approach in response to changing market conditions as well as internal factors.
This suggests that the key challenge for multinational firms is not about choosing between a standardized or adapted approach but rather, managing the balance between them over time, how decisions are coordinated between headquarters and local units, and how strategic implementation is aligned with both organizational priorities and local conditions.

These insights provide an analytical framework, guiding the empirical investigation (see Figure 2). The framework captures international marketing strategy as a process where firms balance standardization and adaptation across multiple markets through implementation and coordination between headquarters and local units. While previous research has established the importance of balancing standardization and adaptation, the reviewed literature also suggests that this balance cannot be understood independently of organizational implementation. International marketing strategies are shaped by not

only external market conditions, but also by internal organizational capabilities such as coordination structures, resource availability and decision-making processes. The framework therefore assumes that strategic balancing is influenced by both contextual conditions and organizational mechanisms through which strategies are implemented across markets.
The framework integrates three main analytical dimensions which also form the basis for the study's sub-questions. Each sub-question corresponds to one dimension of the framework, ensuring alignment between theory, data collection and analysis.

The framework consists of three main analytical dimensions:

**First dimension: Strategic orientation and strategic balancing**
This dimension focuses on the content of the international marketing strategy and how companies balance standardization and adaptation across markets. It examines which marketing elements, such as value propositions, messaging and communication channels, are standardized or adapted across different market contexts. The dimension captures the company's overall strategic orientation and identifies which elements are considered most critical for maintaining consistency or enabling local responsiveness.

**Second dimension: Drivers shaping the balance**
This dimension identifies the underlying factors influencing the balance between standardization and adaptation and is divided into external and internal drivers.

External drivers include institutional and regulatory conditions, customer expectations, market competition and market dynamics.
Internal drivers include organizational structure, available resources and capabilities, control systems, decision-making authority and coordination between headquarters and local units.
Together, these factors help explain which conditions and pressures influence strategic choices across markets.

**Third dimension: Coordination and implementation**
This last dimension focuses on how international marketing strategies are coordinated and implemented in practice across markets. Particular attention is given to coordination mechanisms between headquarters and local units, including formal guidelines, communication routines, processes and organizational structures. The dimension further examines how companies maintain strategic alignment while still allowing necessary local adjustments across markets.

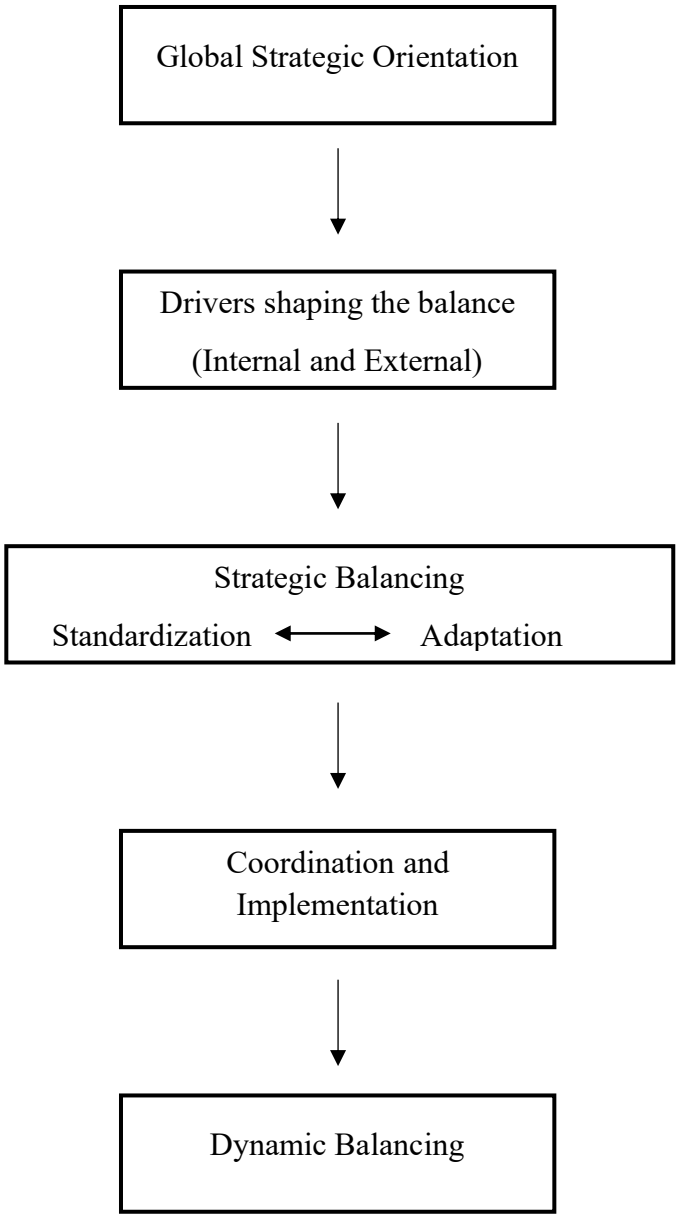



*Figure 2. Analytical Framework for balancing standardization and adaptation in Nordic B2B firms.*

To conclude, the analytical framework guides both the interviews and the analysis. The interviews were structured to capture which marketing elements companies choose to standardize or adapt, which internal and external factors shape these decisions, and how coordination and implementation processes influence the balance across markets. In the analysis chapter, the framework is used to compare patterns across cases, allowing the study to examine how Nordic B2B service companies manage the balance between standardization and adaptation through ongoing coordination and strategic decision-making between headquarters and local units.

# 3 Methodology

## 3.1 Research approach

This study applies a qualitative research approach to explore how Nordic B2B service companies balance standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across multiple markets. A qualitative method was considered suitable as the study aims to gain an in-depth understanding of strategic decision-making processes, organizational perspectives and contextual factors influencing marketing strategies. According to Björklund and Paulsson (2003), qualitative research enables deeper insights into complex organizational phenomena and specific situations that may influence the outcomes of a study.

The study is based on an interpretivist perspective, where knowledge is understood as socially constructed through the experiences and interpretations of the participants. This perspective is appropriate as the study seeks to understand how companies interpret and manage the balance between standardization and adaptation in different Nordic market contexts. Through this interpretivist approach, patterns and themes were identified based on the interaction between theory and empirical material, enabling a deeper understanding of the participants' perspectives and experiences (Hornikx et al., 2023).

Furthermore, the study follows an abductive research logic. Existing theories regarding standardization and adaptation in international marketing provided the initial analytical framework guiding the interviews and analysis. At the same time, empirical insights from the interviews contributed to refining the understanding of how Nordic B2B service companies balance standardization and adaptation in practice. The abductive approach was therefore considered suitable as the study moved iteratively between theory and empirical findings throughout the research process (Dubois & Gadde, 2002).

## 3.2 Research design and data collection

To address the purpose of the study, both primary and secondary data were collected. The primary data consisted of semi-structured in-depth interviews with respondents from Nordic B2B service companies operating across different markets. Semi-structured interviews were selected because they provide a balance between structure and flexibility, allowing respondents to elaborate on their experiences and strategic perspectives while ensuring consistency across interviews. The primary data served as the primary foundation for the empirical analysis of this study.

In total, seven individuals from five Nordic B2B service companies were interviewed. The respondents held positions within marketing, strategy, business development and communication and were selected based on their involvement in international marketing decisions and cross-market coordination activities.

Three respondents were interviewed within Company C, while the remaining companies were represented by one respondent each. As the purpose of the study was to develop an in-depth understanding of how Nordic B2B service companies manage international

marketing strategies across markets, an equal number of respondents from each organization was not considered necessary. The additional respondents provided greater insight into organizational coordination and strategic decision-making, thereby enriching the empirical material.

The companies were selected through purposive sampling based on three criteria: the company operates within the B2B service sector, the company operates across several markets including the Nordic region, the company possesses substantial expertise and experience within its industry. This selection strategy ensured that the collected insights originated from respondents directly involved in strategic marketing decisions across multiple markets.

By focusing on Nordic B2B service-oriented companies operating across multiple markets, the study enables an in-depth analysis of how firms manage strategic marketing decisions within a relevant regional context. This focus is particularly relevant as service-oriented firms may face specific challenges related to value delivery and managing customer relationships. By examining strategic marketing decisions across Nordic B2B service firms, the study aims to provide insights relevant for companies managing marketing strategies across multiple markets.

The interviews lasted between 30 and 60 minutes and were conducted either in person or through video conferencing depending on geographical accessibility and the participant's availability. This flexible interview format enabled broader participation and facilitated a more comprehensive data collection process.

An interview guide was developed based on the study's theoretical framework presented in chapter 2. A semi-structured format was used in order to combine consistency across interviews with flexible follow-up questions and deeper discussions. This approach was considered suitable as it allowed respondents to elaborate on their experiences and strategic perspectives while ensuring that all interviews addressed the central themes relevant to the study's purpose. The interview guide was structured around the three main analytical dimensions identified in the framework: strategic orientation, drivers shaping the balance, and coordination and implementation. These dimensions were translated into broader interview themes and open-ended questions designed to capture respondents' experiences, strategic considerations and organizational practices related to balancing standardization and adaptation. In addition, the flexible structure of the interview guide made it possible to explore unexpected insights and emerging themes during the interviews, contributing to a more nuanced understanding of how Nordic B2B service companies manage marketing strategies across different markets. The interview guide is presented in the appendix section at the end of the thesis.

To ensure confidentiality, all companies and respondents were anonymized throughout the study. Participation was voluntary and all participants received information regarding the purpose of the study, how the data would be used and their right to withdraw from the study at any stage without negative consequences (Alsaleh et al., 2019).

Five companies were interviewed in total and an overview of them can be found in Table 1.

*Table 1. Description of interviewed companies*

| **Pseudonym** | **Industry** | **Markets** | **Respondent role** | **Organizational structure** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Company A | Consulting services | Nordic and global | Business development and marketing | Decentralized |
| Company B | Communication solutions | Nordic region | Nordic marketing manager | Hybrid |
| Company C | Financial services | Nordic region | Strategic, growth and marketing roles | Nordic coordination structure |
| Company D | Financial consulting | Nordic and European | PR manager | Centralized with local units |
| Company E | Energy solutions | Nordic and global | Business development and marketing | Centralized with local execution |

## 3.3 Secondary sources and Contextual Information

In addition to the primary data collected through interviews, the study also incorporated secondary data consisting of peer-reviewed academic articles and methodological sources. The secondary data was primarily used for theoretical development and contextual understanding, while the empirical analysis was based on the primary interview data.

The literature contributed to the analytical framework related to international marketing strategy, the balance between standardization and adaptation, and coordination and implementation across markets. It also complemented the interview material by providing broader theoretical perspectives and additional insight into strategic challenges faced by Nordic B2B service companies, thereby strengthening the interpretation and credibility of the findings.

Only peer-reviewed academic articles and methodological sources were included to ensure the quality, reliability and academic credibility of the study (Ross & Heggestad, 2020). The literature selection was primarily based on relevance to the research topic and contemporary discussions within international marketing strategy literature, while still incorporating foundational theoretical contributions where necessary.

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In addition to the interview data, contextual organizational observations were utilized to support the interpretation of the findings. These observations were obtained through participation in organizational meetings and interactions within one of the studied companies. The observations provided additional insight into coordination processes, communication routines and organizational interactions, thereby contributing to a deeper understanding of the empirical context. While these observations supported the interpretation of the interview material, they were not systematically collected or analyzed as primary empirical data.

## 3.4 Operationalization

The operationalization of the study was based on the analytical framework presented in the theoretical chapter and translated into three main analytical dimensions: strategic orientation, drivers shaping this balance, and coordination and implementation (see Figure 2). These dimensions formed the basis of the semi-structured interview guide and ensured alignment between theory, data collection and empirical analysis.

The first dimension, strategic orientation, focused on how companies balance standardization and adaptation across markets. Questions addressed areas such as brand positioning, market presence, strategic priorities and which marketing elements were standardized or locally adapted. The purpose was to identify how companies' approach and manage international marketing strategies across multiple markets.

The second dimension, drivers and influencing factors, focused on the conditions shaping strategic marketing decisions. External factors were examined through questions related to customer expectations, market differences, competition and regulatory conditions, while internal factors included organizational structure, resource availability, decision-making authority and strategic priorities. This dimension aimed to identify which factors influence the balance between standardization and adaptation in practice.

The third dimension, implementation and coordination, focused on how marketing strategies are coordinated and implemented between headquarters and local units. Questions addressed communication routines, distribution of responsibilities, collaboration processes and how alignment between centralized strategic direction and local execution is maintained across markets.

Through this operationalization process, theoretical concepts related to standardization, adaptation and coordination were translated into empirically identifiable themes, enabling the study to examine how Nordic B2B service companies manage international marketing strategies across multiple markets.

## 3.5 Data Analysis

To analyze the collected data, thematic analysis was used. This method enables an in-depth understanding of the strategic choices and considerations made by participants,

highlighting key themes and patterns that emerge from their responses (Hornikx et al., 2023).

The thematic analysis was conducted through several stages.

The interview material was first reviewed multiple times to increase familiarity with the empirical data. Relevant statements, recurring ideas and meaningful patterns related to the research questions and analytical framework were identified and assigned initial codes.

Codes with conceptual similarities were grouped into broader categories connected to the study's analytical framework, including standardization, adaptation, organizational coordination, market-specific conditions and internal organizational factors.

The categories were then analyzed further to identify overarching themes and recurring patterns across the interviews. This stage focused on understanding how respondents described and interpreted the balance between standardization and adaptation within their organizations.

A comparison of recurring themes, similarities and differences across companies and respondents was conducted to support the interpretation of the findings. The purpose was not to compare companies as individual cases, but rather to identify broader patterns related to how Nordic B2B service companies manage the balance between standardization and adaptation.

Finally, the identified themes and patterns were connected back to the theoretical framework and previous research concerning international marketing strategy, the balance between standardization and adaptation, and coordination across markets.

## 3.6 Research quality

### 3.6.1 Credibility

Credibility was strengthened through purposive sampling, ensuring that respondents possessed relevant experience and strategic insight related to international marketing decisions and coordination across markets. The use of semi-structured interviews enabled consistency across interviews while still allowing flexibility for follow-up questions and further exploration of individual perspectives.

Furthermore, continuous comparison between empirical findings and existing theory contributed to increasing the credibility of the interpretations (Hornikx et al., 2023).

In addition, contextual organizational observations provided further insight into coordination processes and organizational interactions, supporting the interpretation of the interview material and contributing to a richer understanding of the empirical context.

Potential respondent bias was also considered, as respondents may have presented their organizations and strategic processes in a favorable manner. To reduce this risk, anonymity and confidentiality were emphasized throughout the research process, encouraging more open and reflective responses.

### 3.6.2 Transferability

Transferability was strengthened through detailed contextual descriptions of the participating companies, respondents and organizational settings, enabling readers to assess the relevance of the findings in similar contexts. Including companies operating across different service industries and organizational structures further enabled the study to capture varied perspectives and experiences within Nordic B2B service companies operating across multiple markets.

### 3.6.3 Dependability

Dependability was strengthened through a transparent description of the research design, interview process, operationalization and analytical procedures. The interview guide was consistently applied across all interviews while still allowing flexibility for follow-up discussions.

The analytical process was also conducted systematically through coding, categorization and cross-case comparison, contributing to analytical consistency and transparency throughout the process.

### 3.6.4 Confirmability

Confirmability was strengthened through continuous reflection on the researchers' interpretations and analytical choices throughout the study (Gornall & Maxwell, 2013). Critical discussions and ongoing reflection were conducted during both data collection and analysis in order to reduce the influence of researcher bias and interpretative subjectivity.

The researchers were also aware that respondents may have presented their organizations in a strategically favorable manner. In addition, the interpretation of qualitative data is inevitably influenced by the researchers' own perspectives and analytical choices. Ongoing reflexivity was therefore applied to strengthen analytical transparency and reduce potential bias.

Through these methodological considerations, the study aims to maintain a high standard of scientific and ethical research practice.

## 3.7 Ethical Considerations

Ethical considerations were addressed throughout the research process to ensure responsible handling of participants and collected data (Welch & Welch, 2008). A central ethical consideration concerned informed consent. This means that each interview participant was provided with clear and straightforward information about the purpose of the study, the methods used, and how their data would be used (Flory et al., 2005). The respondents were given the opportunity to ask questions before confirming their participation. They were also informed that participation was voluntary and that they can withdraw from the study at any time without negative consequences (Alsaleh et al., 2019).

Collected data was stored securely, accessible only to the researchers, and used solely for the purposes of this study. Participant privacy and confidentiality were therefore carefully protected throughout the research process. All identifiable participant information was anonymized and is therefore not disclosed in the study (Welch & Welch, 2008).

## 3.8 Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Artificial intelligence (AI) tools were employed in a limited capacity during the development of this study. Its primary function was to support the writing process by assisting with language refinement and sentence construction. At the initial stage of the project, AI was also used to explore potential research directions.

However, the identification, selection and evaluation of scientific sources were carried out independently by the authors. Decisions regarding the inclusion of literature were based solely on the authors' assessment of relevance and methodological quality.

AI was not involved in the processing, interpretation or analysis of the empirical data. Likewise, it did not contribute to the formulation of the study´s findings or conclusions. All analytical work and academic judgments were conducted by the authors.

Any content generated with AI assistance was carefully reviewed, revised and adapted before being incorporated into the study. Full responsibility for the final text, interpretations and conclusions remains with the authors.

# 4 Empirical Findings

This chapter presents the empirical findings based on the interviews conducted with five different Nordic B2B service companies operating across multiple markets. In some cases, multiple respondents were interviewed within the same organization, representing roles in marketing, strategy and business development, while in most cases a single respondent represented the company. Details about the interviewed companies and respondents are presented in Table 1 in the methodology chapter.

To ensure confidentiality, all companies and respondents were anonymized. The findings are structured thematically in line with the study's analytical framework, covering the overall international marketing strategy approach, the drivers of standardization and adaptation, the coordination mechanisms and finally, the strategic challenges and opportunities associated with the companies' current approaches.

## 4.1 Case Overview

**Company A** is a medium-sized Nordic B2B technology consulting firm operating across both Nordic and international markets. The company specializes in technology-driven advisory and strategic consulting services for business clients across multiple industries. In addition to its Nordic presence, the company also works with clients outside of Europe, including North America and Asia. While operating independently, the company is also part of a larger international professional service network, creating opportunities for collaboration across markets.

The company has approximately 1,000 employees and operates through a relatively lean organizational structure consisting of a central headquarters supported by smaller local market units. Compared to larger multinational firms, the company has more limited marketing resources and local market presence, while still managing communication activities across diverse international markets.

The respondent works within business development and marketing, with responsibilities related to brand positioning, client acquisition and international communication activities.

**Company B** operates across the Nordic markets, including Sweden, Denmark, Norway and Finland. The company is an established company within business communication and information management solutions, offering both digital and physical services to organizations with large customer bases. Its operations primarily focus on customer communication management, omnichannel distribution, print and mail services, invoicing solutions and digital communication platforms.

The company has a strong Nordic presence and serves clients across both the private and public sector. While the organization is regionally focused, it operates within an industry characterized by international competition and ongoing digital transformation. Company B combines centralized strategic governance with locally embedded operational teams. The company follows a matrix-like Nordic structure where strategic functions such as business development, technology and management are coordinated

across markets, while country-level teams manage customer relationships and operational delivery.

Company B is considered a well-established provider within the Nordic communication solutions industry and differentiates itself through its integrated offering of both digital and physical communication services, as well as its long-standing customer relationships.

The respondent serves as the Nordic Marketing Manager, overseeing strategic marketing initiatives across the region.

**Company C** is a large Nordic financial institution operating across multiple markets within the Nordic region. The company serves both in B2B and B2C segments and holds an established position within the Nordic banking and financial services industry. The company operates through a centralized Nordic structure combined with locally embedded market units responsible for customer interaction and market-specific activities.

The organization is structured around a centralized Nordic operating model supported by local market units across the region. Due to the company's scale and broad service offering, marketing and communication activities involve several functions and business areas across different markets.

Three respondents were interviewed within Company C, representing different strategic and operational perspectives across the funnel. The first respondent works as strategic lead on a Nordic level and will be referred to as Respondent A. The second respondent works as Lead Marketing Partner in Sweden, this respondent will be referred to as Respondent B**.** Lastly, the third respondent is responsible for roles related to both creative leadership and Nordic growth initiatives and will be referred as Respondent C throughout this chapter.

As three respondents were interviewed within Company C, this case is given more space in the Empirical findings and analysis.

**Company D** is a large Nordic B2B financial consulting company operating across several European markets, primarily within the Nordic region. The company provides advisory and intermediary services within complex financial areas such as insurance, pensions, wealth management and corporate financial solutions.

The company has a strong market presence in Sweden, Norway, Denmark, Finland and additional European markets, serving both corporate and private clients. Company D operates through a centralized strategic structure combined with locally embedded offices and advisory teams, enabling coordinated governance while maintaining close customer relationships in local markets.

Company D is considered a well-established and influential actor with a strong position in the Nordic financial advisory market. Relevant characteristics of the company include its broad advisory offering, decentralized customer-facing operations, long-term client

relationships and strategic focus on growth, acquisitions and specialized financial expertise.

The respondent serves as PR Manager, with responsibility for communication and brand-related activities.

**Company E** is a large Nordic industrial B2B company operating within the global energy sector. The company provides energy-related products, technical solutions and services to business customers across multiple international markets. The organization maintains a strong international presence and operates within an industry characterized by technological development, large-scale projects and varying regional market conditions.

The company operates through a regional organizational structure supported by central strategic functions across different business areas. Due to the company's international operations, activities are conducted across several markets and regional contexts.

The respondent works within business development and marketing, with responsibilities related to strategic market development and coordination across markets.

## 4.2 International Marketing Strategy approach

Company A explains that due to limited resources, the company currently has a rather standardized approach across all markets and has limited possibilities for local adaptation.

The company has clients not only in Nordic markets but all over the world, from the US to Korea, the respondent highlights that if they are doing marketing for example, in China, they either cooperate with a local company or a parent company to support local adaptation particularly regarding language and communication. Furthermore, they optimize their email campaigns to clients in Germany, where it is very important to use a correct title, like Mr/Ms/Dr etc. – "*it is seen that a junior employee sends out this email on behalf of the senior employees as this is seen as a respectful gesture for the clients in Germany*". The respondent is quick to highlight that this is not something they would do to a Scandinavian company.

The respondent further explains the weight of cultural differences and its impact on the company's marketing strategy. While the company currently have a standardized marketing strategy, they work hard to adapt their marketing, especially in China. "*We need to use different channels in China compared to Europe and NA. For example, they don't use LinkedIn and instead have a few super apps and much of the marketing take place within WeChat groups*." - Respondent, Company A.

Lastly, the respondent mentions that while Company A is more standardized, with their parent company applying a more locally adapted approach, as they have a bigger footprint of local offices and have the resources to do so.

Company B is organized around a fully Nordic operating model, while still allowing local adaptation to remain close to customers and market-specific needs. The

organization is in a phase of activating a renewed brand platform while simultaneously using marketing to support digital sales growth, lead generation and cross- and upselling activities.

The respondent states that Company B is always focused on both brand building and sales activation. This is because they view branding and sales as interconnected activities of the customer journey, rather than treating them as separate initiatives.

For Company C, three respondents describe the company's marketing strategy as largely built around a Nordic approach, while still allowing for local adaptation.

Respondent A explains that the company operates within all Nordic home markets: Sweden, Norway, Denmark and Finland but highlights that the brand strategy is common across all markets. According to respondent A, there is one shared brand strategy and one common communication platform, rather than specific separate country approaches. "*We have our marketing communication platform, which is the same – no country has its own concepts, it is one common idea*."

The respondent further explains that this standardized strategic core is developed centrally but points out that local units are responsible for adapting certain elements such as languages and culture.

"*On the marketing side, there is a division where much of the productions and messaging is developed at a Nordic level, and then local teams adapt language and to some extent, cultural differences*." – Respondent A (Translated from Swedish)

Respondent B describes a shift toward a more Nordic approach but highlights that it has shifted between a Nordic and local approach in the past. Further, Respondent B explains when previously working more locally - *"There was greater independence and control in how work is planned and carried out, as budgeting was also supported locally."* However, the organization has now shifted to a Nordic approach, meaning that it operates through Nordic teams and shared initiatives. Respondent B further describes that even though it is a Nordic approach, not all elements are treated equally. According to the respondent, certain parts of marketing, such as brand, overall strategy and creative direction, are more suitable for scaling while other activities, such as media mix, events and customer-facing activities, are described as more locally adapted.

"*In the execution, countries look somewhat different. In terms of positioning, it is not exactly the same, and what is being marketed and highlighted is not identical*." - Respondent B

Respondent C further explains that the company works with common Nordic assets and messaging, which are then adapted to local contexts. Respondent C describes how creative materials and narratives are developed centrally and later adjusted depending on market, channel or customer segment. At the same time, the respondent further emphasizes that communication is often shaped by customer insights and specific situations such as different stages in the customer journey. Respondent C says: "*I believe you should start with consumer insights…what needs these businesses have and what they find difficult.*"

All three respondents from Company C describe their strategy as a shared Nordic foundation, combined with a certain degree of adaptation depending on the type of marketing activity.

Company D operates across seven countries: Sweden, Denmark, Norway, Finland, The Netherlands, England and Spain, while the primary focus is on the Nordic market. The respondent explained that each country manages its own marketing initiatives independently, yet all must align with a unified overarching brand strategy. They described this approach as "balanced", integrating a standardized framework with adaptation to cater to specific market needs. As the respondent noted, "*This strategy aims to build a unified brand while allowing us to be flexible according to the different markets*".

Company E's marketing strategy can be described as a hybrid approach between standardization and adaptation. The respondent explains that while the strategic core, such as the core offering and overall positioning, are largely standardized, the execution is adapted to different markets, describing it as "*quite a balanced setup*" (Respondent, Company E).

The respondent further highlights that the strategy is highly adapted to specific clients, while maintaining a standardized core, the respondent explains that "*the product is standardized and then we try to adapt it to various regions"*.

Further, the respondent explains that the headquarters defines key elements such as positioning, priorities and brand, while local markets are responsible for adapting how these are executed.

Across the cases, the findings show that none of the companies apply a fully standardized or fully localized marketing strategy. Instead, all companies combine a standardized strategic core with varying degrees of local adaptation. However, the extent of adaptation differs depending on resources, organizational structure and market scope.

## 4.3 Drivers of Standardization and Adaptation

When discussing the decision-making process and the factors influencing standardization or adaptation, Company A responded that their decision regarding marketing is driven by both internal and external factors. For the external factors, they mainly look at the competitors' strategies, what they are doing and what works well for them. Furthermore, the company has gathered a lot of experience for over a decade from operating across different countries around the world. As mentioned before, the main adaptation is also heavily centered around how they convey their messaging between countries due to cultural differences and norms. The respondent continues by explaining that internal factors influence their decision-making just as much. As the company only operate through two offices while serving clients across international markets, resources are limited. The respondent continues with saying "*As we have rather limited resources, we cannot pursue extensive local adaptation as it takes a lot of resources, so it's always*

*a balance between localizing to be attractive but keep it standardized enough to not cost too much or take too much time*".

The respondent further explains that no employees work full-time with marketing activities, but rather that it is some of the consultants that spend a few hours per week doing the work.

Company B's marketing strategy can be characterized as a hybrid approach, consolidating its efforts into a unified Nordic model while allowing for necessary adaptation.

For Company B, standardization is driven by the need for brand consistency. Key internal elements such as the brand story, purpose, value proposition and visual identity are standardized to maintain a cohesive brand image across all markets. The respondent points out that this consistency is crucial for building trust and recognition among customers. Additionally, by sharing assets and processes across markets, Company B achieves economies of scale that simplify operations and reduce costs. A unified messaging framework further enhances brand recall, ensuring that core values and offerings are communicated consistently across all channels.

On the other hand, the respondent highlights that adaptation is essential for effective execution. While brand-critical elements are standardized, market-facing execution, including campaign focus, messaging emphasis and channel mix, are adapted to fit local preferences and cultural nuances. The respondent states that Nordic countries have unique influencing characteristics, such as varying levels of market maturity, customer needs, regulatory context and business priorities. Adapting marketing strategies to these local conditions is intended to ensure that campaigns resonate well with target audiences. Through this flexibility, Company B strives to respond effectively to changes in market dynamics and customer expectations.

The respondents from Company C describe several factors influencing the balance between standardization and adaptation, including customer insights, efficiency considerations and competitive pressures.

Respondent A explains that the company's brand strategy is based on extensive customer research, where similar needs and expectations were identified across the Nordic markets. Respondent A further highlights that customers across these markets tend to value similar aspects, such as responsibility and expertise, which has supported the development of a common Nordic strategy.

When asked, Respondent B particularly emphasizes efficiency as a key driver. The respondent explains that scaling across markets reduces duplicated work and lengthy processes, especially in areas like creative production and campaign development. The respondent also mentions that this shift is influenced by external competition, particularly from newer and more agile competitors in the financial sector, leading to pressure to work more efficiently and consistently. "*Instead of developing four ideas, you develop one…and when you produce, you do it once instead of four times.*" – Respondent B

Respondent C also highlights the importance of customer insights, particularly in the small and medium-sized businesses segment. Further, the respondent explains that communication is guided by specific situations in the customer journey, such as businesses in different growth stages. At the same time, Respondent C notes that extensive adaptation can be both costly and time-consuming, creating a need to balance relevance with scalability.

Across the respondents from Company C, standardization is often associated with efficiency and shared customer needs, while adaptation is linked to contextual relevance, customer proximity and specific market conditions.

When discussing the drivers behind their strategy with Company D, the respondent pointed out that standardization is primarily motivated by the need for a cohesive brand identity. This includes maintaining a consistent graphic profile, such as specific font types and color schemes, which is highlighted as essential for building brand recognition and trust among customers. Additionally, the respondent highlighted that standardization offers significant efficiency and cost advantages, allowing the company to streamline its operations and reduce expenses across its activities.

On the other hand, the respondent further highlights that the need for adaptation arises from unique local market conditions. The respondent explained that customer preferences, competitive dynamics and cultural nuances vary between countries, necessitating that Company D adapts its offerings to resonate more effectively with local audiences. They emphasized that external factors like the competitive landscape and customer behaviors influence how marketing strategies are crafted in each market. Internally, the size of marketing teams and the availability of resources also play a crucial role in determining what can be executed locally. For example, the respondent states, *"A larger marketing team may have the capacity to implement more extensive localized strategies, while smaller teams might rely more heavily on standardized approaches."*

Lastly, the respondent from Company E describes that the balance between standardization and adaptation is influenced by a combination of external and internal factors.

Externally, factors such as market maturity, regulations, competition and customer needs are highlighted as key influences. Regulation is described as particularly important in the energy sector as the respondent explains:" *Regulation plays a huge role… it can literally decide whether a market grows or not*."

Furthermore, differences in customer segments and market maturity influence how value propositions are communicated. For example, in more mature markets communication tends to focus on efficiency and cost, while in less mature markets, aspects such as scalability and accessibility are emphasized.

Internally, the respondent highlights factors such as organizational structure, resource availability and the development of solutions, "*if a new turbine platform is not fully rolled out yet, you won't push it equally everywhere*."

## 4.4 Coordination and Implementation Across Markets

Company A explains that since the organization only operates through two offices, the decision-making is handled locally but the respondent mention that there are more or less, no differences between the two units. Furthermore, they work closely between the offices and have the same target groups.

Decision-making within Company B reflects a combination of centralized strategy and decentralized execution. At the Nordic level, the company sets the strategic direction, brand framework and overall marketing priorities. This centralized approach strives to ensure a consistent brand identity and direction across all markets. However, local marketing units are responsible for execution, local campaign planning, and market-specific adjustments. This decentralized structure allows local units to adapt their strategies based on their in-depth understanding of local markets.

For Company B, coordination is achieved through several mechanisms. The company uses a shared brand platform and marketing roadmap, which serves as a guide for all local units, ensuring alignment with the overarching strategy while allowing for adaptation in execution. Establishing common key performance indicators (KPIs) also plays a crucial role in measuring the success of marketing activities across different markets, ensuring that all teams work towards shared objectives. The respondent points out that there is an ongoing collaboration between Nordic and local units to foster knowledge sharing and best practices, "*This structure enables local units to act independently while staying aligned with the overall strategy*."

All respondents from Company C describe the aspects related to coordination between Nordic and local levels, particularly in terms of processes, roles and collaboration.

Respondent A begins by explaining that working across multiple markets involves a large number of handoffs and coordination points. The respondent describes that activities are often replicated across all four operating markets which can lead to many people being involved in the decision-making process, "*There are many handovers... quite a lot of people that needs to have an opinion.*" The respondent further emphasizes that this can result in longer timelines and multiple rounds of feedback, reducing efficiency.

Further, Respondent B provides a detailed account of the transition from a more local perspective. The respondent describes that this shift has led to uncertainty around responsibilities and budgets, as well as an increase in meetings and coordination efforts between Nordic and local units. The respondent also highlights that while Nordic and local structures exist simultaneously, it can lead to overlapping work and unclear ownership in some cases.

Respondent C describes the coordination as a process that requires collaboration between different types of expertise. Respondent C explains that both centrally developed concepts and local market knowledge are important and that effective implementation involves combining these perspectives. The respondent continues by explaining "*You always need someone close to the market…in combination with*

*someone who has worked with the concept based on customer insights*". At the same time, the respondent highlights that organizational and cultural factors, such as differing opinions and interests can influence how decisions are made and implemented.

Overall, Company C describes coordination as multi-level process involving several actors responsible for balancing centralized structures with local market input.

The respondent from Company D elaborated on the coordination process, stating that overall strategic direction comes from the headquarters, but execution and accountability largely rest with the local units.

They described the process from strategy to execution as rapid and test-driven. Local units are encouraged to test various marketing campaigns, evaluate the effectiveness of messages and results, and make necessary adjustments. This approach enables the company to remain flexible and responsive to changing market conditions. The respondent notes that the relatively short transition from idea or strategy to execution allows Company D to capitalize on emerging opportunities quickly.

Company E operates with a centralized structure where headquarters sets overall strategic direction, while local units are responsible for execution. The respondent explains that headquarters defines priorities, such as which segments or solutions to focus on, while local units adapt campaigns and activities to fit local conditions. As the respondent further explains, "HQ *usually sets the big direction and priorities… but local teams have the room to adapt campaigns."*

At the same time, coordination involves ongoing interaction between headquarters and local units. Local units contribute market-specific insights, while headquarters provides strategic alignment.

However, the respondent highlights that this coordination can be challenging, noting that "*Sometimes HQ doesn't fully see the local reality, or local teams feel a bit limited*."

The findings suggest that coordination varies significantly depending on organizational structure, with simpler setups enabling faster decision-making while more complex structures require greater alignment across multiple actors.

## 4.5 Strategic Challenges and Opportunities across markets

The respondent from Company A views the current strategy as a rather good balance between standardization and adaptation, "*We are able to standardize enough to attract new clients but still be cost and time effective in our work*."

When asked about the possible challenges and opportunities regarding the current strategy, the respondent is quick to acknowledge that it is a challenge to find a balance between standardization and adaptation, especially since marketing activities are only handled on a part-time basis. The company understands that adaptation is important to attract new clients but at the same time, they mention that they are aware that too much focus on adaptation will reduce the time available for client-related work and project delivery.

For opportunities, the respondent thinks that they have a good balance today, with the company's growth and with English being the primary used language across most markets, they believe that a standardized approach is preferable for most clients, "*Becoming more localized would likely not be that beneficial, as we would see diminishing returns. I believe that we need to think about becoming more standardized to save resources, however, standardizing too fast could jeopardize our efforts, so it is important to introduce a more standardized approach slowly*." – Respondent (Company A).

Company B's marketing strategy presents both opportunities and challenges. The respondent states that one of the primary opportunities is the potential for stronger brand consistency, which enhances customer trust and loyalty. By having a hybrid approach, the company can position itself more clearly as a Nordic digitalization partner, attracting new customers and business opportunities. Additionally, economies of scale achieved through shared assets and processes enable the company to utilize resources more efficiently, ultimately reducing costs and increasing profitability.

However, the respondent notes that challenges still exist. Variations in market maturity and regulatory environments across the Nordic countries can complicate the implementation of standardized strategies. Moreover, differences in customer preferences necessitate careful adaptations to ensure that marketing efforts resonate with local audiences. There is also a risk that insufficient adaptation could lead to diminished brand relevance in specific markets, undermining overall effectiveness.

The respondents from Company C describe both strengths and challenges related to the current approach, particularly in relation to efficiency, consistency and flexibility.

Respondent A highlights that a shared Nordic strategy allows the company to combine resources and create consistency across markets. Further, Respondent A explains that this can support stronger brand recognition and a more unified presence across markets. However, at the same time, the respondent notes that there are opportunities to further develop how the strategy is implemented, particularly in terms of processes, collaboration with the business and the use of technology.

Respondent B describes both advantages and challenges in the current approach. On one hand, the respondent explains that shared campaigns and creative work can reduce costs and create coordination, but on the other hand, the process can become time-consuming and complex, especially when many stakeholders are involved. "*The risk is that it becomes a bit too slow…and that what you develop becomes somewhat diluted after many rounds.*" The respondent also mentions that there can be challenges in finding a clear structure when both Nordic and local elements are combined.

Respondent C highlights opportunities related to building long-term brand value and consistency while also adapting communication to different segments and situations. The respondent emphasizes "*We want to hold a one brand strategy… to build long-term brand equity and trust*." Further, Respondent C describes the importance of combining scalable systems with the ability to respond to specific contexts, such as different

industries or customer needs. At the same time, Respondent C highlights that some activities require speed and flexibility which can be more difficult to achieve within larger and more coordinated structures.

When discussing challenges and opportunities, Company D noted that the clarity and consistency across countries, along with operational efficiency, are significant advantages.

At the same time, the respondent acknowledged that this standardization also creates challenges due to variations in local markets and competitive landscapes. They explained that differences in market maturity and customer expectations can complicate the implementation of standardized strategies.

The respondent from Company E identifies both strengths and challenges with the current approach. One key advantage is the ability to maintain a consistent global brand while still adapting to local markets. As the respondent summarized: "*You standardize what gives consistency… and you adapt what actually impacts performance*."

At the same time, challenges related to coordination between headquarters and local units are highlighted. Differences in market conditions and perspectives can create tensions, particularly when global strategies do not fully reflect local realities.

Across the interviews, the hybrid approach is described as offering opportunities for efficiency and consistency, while also involving challenges related to coordination, speed and balancing different needs across markets and segments.

At the same time, respondents highlight that variations in local market conditions and competitive landscapes create additional challenges. Differences in the level of market development and customer expectations require adjustments in how strategies are implemented. Several respondents note that a shared framework does not always fully reflect local conditions, which leads to a need for further adaptation in specific markets.

Insights from the interviews are summarized in Table 2, providing a cross-case overview of the companies' strategic approaches, dominant drivers, coordination structures and key challenges related to balancing standardization and adaptation across markets.

*Table 2. Cross-case summary of strategic approaches, drivers, coordination structures and challenges across the interviewed companies.*

| **Theme** | **Company A** | **Company B** | **Company C** | **Company D** | **Company E** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Strategy | Standardized Core + small local adapt. | Nordic core + local adaptation | Nordic core + local adaptation | Standardized core + local adaptation | Standardized Core and local adaptation. |
| Drivers | Resources and customer culture | Efficiency and strategic alignment | Efficiency and customer insights | Branding, efficiency and local differences | Regulations, market maturity, customer needs, resources |
| Coordination | Global structure | Nordic-local complexity | Nordic-local complexity | Unified with local complexity | Global structure and local execution |
| Challenges | Resource limitations | Market differences and relevance risk | Speed, clarity and structure | Variations in markets and competitive landscapes | Alignment, HQ and local tension |

As illustrated in Table 2, all five companies apply a hybrid approach that combines elements of standardization and local adaptation. However, the findings indicate that the underlying drivers and organizational conditions shaping this balance differ across cases. While some companies are primarily influenced by internal organizational conditions such as resources and strategic alignment, others are more strongly shaped by external market conditions, including customer expectations, regulations and market-specific differences.

# 5 Analysis

This chapter analyzes the empirical findings in relation to the theoretical framework presented in Chapter 2. The analysis is structured according to the same themes presented in the empirical findings chapter: international marketing strategy approach, drivers shaping standardization and adaptation, coordination and implementation, and strategic challenges and opportunities. Based on the analysis, the analytical framework presented in Chapter 2 is further refined.

## 5.1 International Marketing Strategy Approach

The empirical findings indicate that all studied companies apply a hybrid approach, where the strategic core is generally standardized, while selected market elements are adapted across markets.

However, rather than reflecting a uniform strategic orientation, the findings reveal important differences in how and why companies structure this balance across markets.

While prior research conceptualizes standardization and adaptation as alternative strategic choices, the findings support the view that companies instead combine both approaches across different marketing elements (Vrontis, 2003; Zou & Cavusgil, 2002). In line with Zou and Cavusgil's (2002) global marketing strategy framework, companies make interconnected decisions regarding product, communication, pricing and distribution. However, the findings extend this perspective by suggesting that the balance is shaped not only by market differences, but also by internal organizational conditions such as resources, organizational structure and coordination capabilities across markets.

A key insight emerges regarding the extent to which this balance is actively managed and constrained by internal conditions. For example, Company A demonstrates a more standardized approach, heavily driven by limited resources. Although the company adapts selectively in specific contexts, such as China and Germany, adaptation appears to be more reactive instead of strategically embedded. In contrast, other companies such as Company B and Company C apply a more structured and strategic hybrid model, where standardization and adaptation are used as complementary tools to balance efficiency and local responsiveness. This suggests that the ability to implement a hybrid approach depends not only on strategic intent, but also on organizational capabilities and internal resource conditions.

Further, Company C illustrates this more strategic approach through a shared Nordic foundation, where core elements such as brand strategy, communication platforms and messaging are developed centrally, while local units are responsible for implementation. This reflects what Zou and Cavusgil (2002) describe as selective standardization, while further highlighting how such an approach depends on the organization's ability to coordinate activities across markets. Similarly, Company B combines a centralized brand platform with local adaptation in channels and campaigns, indicating a clear

difference between strategic and operational elements. This aligns with integrated marketing communication theory (Batra & Keller, 2016), while also reflecting the interdependent relationship between global orientation and local responsiveness described by Lee and Griffith (2019).

Furthermore, the findings suggest that the degree of marketing influence within the organization plays a key role in shaping how this balance is executed in practice. In line with Homburg et al. (1999), marketing's influence is not only determined by external market conditions, but also by internal organizational factors. This suggests that companies with stronger coordination structures and clearer strategic alignment, such as Company B and Company C, are better positioned to actively manage the balance, whereas companies with more limited resources or less formalized structures, such as Company A, face greater constraints in their ability to adapt.

Across all cases, standardization and adaptation are managed at the level of specific marketing elements rather than through a singular strategic orientation. Core elements such as brand identity and value proposition are largely standardized, while executional elements such as campaigns, channels and messaging are adapted. This is evident in Company E, where the product and overall positioning remain standardized, while communication varies depending on market maturity and regulatory conditions. Company D further shows a similar approach, aiming to maintain brand consistency while adapting to local market dynamics.

While these findings support the AdaptStand perspective (Vrontis, 2003; Vrontis et al., 2009), it is further refined by showing that the balance is not implemented uniformly across companies. Instead, it is shaped by a combination of organizational structure, resource availability and coordination capabilities. In this sense, companies do not simply choose standardization and adaptation but instead operate within organizational conditions that enable or constrain how this balance can be implemented in practice. This extends the AdaptStand perspective by suggesting that the implementation of hybrid strategies depends not only on strategic intent, but also on organizational capabilities available to support adaptation across markets.

Overall, the findings suggest that international marketing should not be understood as a fixed strategic position, but rather as an ongoing balancing process applied across different marketing elements and organizational levels. While this aligns with previous research, the findings further suggest that the underlying logic shaping this balance differs significantly across companies. This indicates that international marketing strategy is shaped not only by market conditions, but also by company-specific capabilities and internal organizational dynamics.

## 5.2 Drivers of Standardization and Adaptation

The findings show that the balance between standardization and adaptation is shaped by a combination of external and internal factors. While prior research highlights the importance of both institutional environments and organizational factors (Rao-Nicholson & Khan, 2017; Katsikeas et al., 2020), the empirical findings suggest that these factors influence the balance differently depending on the company's organizational structure, resources and market conditions.

External factors such as regulations, cultural norms, market conditions and customer expectations shape where adaptation becomes necessary. As highlighted by Rao-Nicholson and Khan (2017), differences across institutional environments require companies to adjust how strategies are executed in different markets. This pattern is evident across all cases. For instance, Company B adapts its messaging and channel choices based on regulatory conditions and market developments across the Nordic countries, while Company A adjusts its approach in specific markets such as China and Germany due to cultural and institutional differences. Similarly, Company C highlights how customer segments and cultural norms influence how marketing elements are adapted across markets.

This pattern is further strengthened by Company E, where external factors such as market maturity, regulation, competition and customer needs strongly influence the degree of adaptation. In particular, regulation is described as a key driver shaping both market opportunities and how offerings can be positioned. This supports earlier research, suggesting that institutional differences across markets require companies to adapt their strategies to maintain relevance and legitimacy (Szymanski et al., 1993; Rao-Nicholson & Khan, 2017). Company D similarly highlights how competitive dynamics and customer behavior influence marketing decisions across markets, reinforcing the role of external market conditions in shaping strategic responses (Katsikeas et al., 2020).

While these findings show that external factors create the need for adaptation, internal organizational conditions largely determine the extent to which companies are able to respond effectively across markets. This indicates that the balance between standardization and adaptation is not only shaped by market-specific pressures but also by organizational capabilities, resource availability and strategic priorities within the organization.

Internal factors such as organizational structure, resource availability and marketing capabilities influence the extent to which companies are able to adapt their strategies in practice (Rao-Nicholson & Khan, 2017). Company A, for example, illustrates how limited resources constrain the ability to implement localized strategies, resulting in a more standardized approach despite operating across diverse markets.

In contrast, companies such as Company B, Company C and Company D, which operate with more developed marketing functions and organizational structures,

demonstrate a greater capacity to combine standardization and adaptation across markets.

In addition, the findings indicate that internal strategic priorities influence how companies approach this balance. Company B emphasizes efficiency and scalability, and therefore relies more heavily on standardized processes and shared assets, while Company C places greater emphasis on customer insights and communication relevance, resulting in more context-specific adaptations. This aligns with Aguinis and Burgi-Tian (2023), who argue that internal performance priorities shape strategic orientation. This further reflects the complexity of international marketing strategy, where decisions are influenced not only by external conditions but also by internal capabilities and managerial priorities (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002; Katsikeas et al., 2020).

Furthermore, the role of marketing within the organization appears to influence how these drivers are translated into practice. In line with Homburg et al. (1999), marketing's influence is shaped not only by external conditions, but also by internal organizational factors. Companies with a stronger strategic role for marketing and clearer coordination structures appear to be better positioned to manage competing strategic demands across markets. In contrast, companies with more limited marketing resources or less integrated structures face greater challenges in responding to external pressures.

Taken together, these findings suggest that external factors explain where adaptation becomes necessary, while internal factors determine the company's actual response. Rather than representing separate categories, these drivers interact continuously and shape how companies manage the balance between standardization and adaptation in practice. This extends prior research by demonstrating that the balance is not only influenced by market conditions, but also by the company's ability to operationalize strategic choices within its organizational context (Poulis, 2024).

## 5.3 Coordination and implementation

The findings indicate that coordination plays a central role in shaping how strategic balancing is implemented across markets. While prior research identifies coordination as a key dimension of global marketing strategy (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002), the results suggest that coordination is not only an enabling mechanism but also a source of complexity and constraint in practice.

A key difference can be observed between companies operating through relatively simple organizational structures and those characterized by more complex coordination systems. Company A, which involves a limited number of offices and organizational actors, demonstrates a more straightforward coordination process that enables faster decision-making and alignment across markets. In contrast, Company C illustrates how increased organizational complexity, multiple stakeholders and overlapping responsibilities may lead to slower processes, extended decision-making and, in some cases, weaker strategic outcomes.

These findings suggest that coordination should not only be understood as a mechanism for achieving alignment. As organizational complexity increases, coordination structures may simultaneously support consistency while also creating slower decision-making processes, overlapping responsibilities and reduced strategic clarity. Although such structures are intended to ensure consistency, they may also reduce speed and clarity in the decision-making process. This further extends the perspective of Ambos et al. (2010), who emphasize the role of local initiative-taking by showing that coordination structures can both enable and constrain strategic implementation depending on how they are organized.

Furthermore, the findings indicate that coordination is not only structural but also relational. In line with Poulis' (2024) research, the balance between standardization and adaptation is continuously shaped through interaction between headquarters and local units. For example, Company E highlights tensions between central strategic priorities and local market realities, indicating that alignment is negotiated rather than defined centrally. Similarly, Company C demonstrates how coordination involves ongoing interaction between multiple actors, where different perspectives continuously shape how strategies are implemented in practice. This interpretation is further supported by contextual organizational observations, which highlighted how coordination and interaction between organizational actors constituted an ongoing part of managing marketing activities across markets.

At the same time, companies such as Company B illustrate how coordination mechanisms, including shared brand platforms, common KPIs and ongoing collaboration, support alignment while allowing for local flexibility. This reflects the integrated marketing communication perspective (Batra & Keller, 2016), where a standardized strategic core is combined with local adaptation in execution. The findings further suggest that achieving this balance depends not only on formal coordination mechanisms but also on continuous interaction between organizational actors across markets. In this regard, the findings extend the coordination dimension of global marketing strategy (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002) by illustrating how alignment is maintained in practice.

In addition, the findings suggest that the role and influence of marketing within the organization affect how coordination is carried out in practice. This is supported by Homburg et al. (1999), who argue that marketing's influence is shaped not only by external conditions, but also by internal organizational factors. Companies where marketing holds a more central and integrated role appear to be better positioned to align strategic priorities and operational activities across markets. In contrast, companies operating through more fragmented organizational structures may experience greater coordination and implementation challenges.

Finally, the variation observed across the five companies reflects varying approaches to international marketing strategy, where coordination structures and strategic approaches evolve depending on both internal organizational conditions and external market

conditions (Solberg & Durrieu, 2023). This indicates that coordination practices differ depending on company-specific contexts.

Overall, coordination emerges as a dynamic and highly context-dependent process where the effectiveness of strategic alignment depends on the interaction between organizational structure, decision-making authority and market-specific conditions. This reinforces the view that international marketing strategy is not only concerned with designing a hybrid strategic approach, but also with managing how strategic priorities are coordinated and implemented across organizational levels and market contexts.

## 5.4 Strategic challenges and opportunities

The hybrid approaches identified across the findings create both opportunities and challenges, reinforcing prior research on the complexity of balancing standardization and adaptation (Vrontis et al., 2009; Poulis, 2024). However, rather than representing separate outcomes, these opportunities and challenges are closely interconnected, emerging from the same underlying strategic logic.

A key opportunity identified across companies is the ability to achieve efficiency and scalability through standardization, while maintaining market relevance through adaptation. Shared campaigns, centralized assets and coordinated processes enable companies such as Company B, Company C and Company D to reduce costs and streamline production, supporting the benefits of a standardized strategic core highlighted in prior research (Batra & Keller, 2016; Zou & Cavusgil, 2002). Similarly, Company E demonstrates how a combination of a standardized core and local adaptation allows companies to achieve both global consistency and market-specific relevance. This reflects the view of international marketing strategy as a set of interconnected decisions across multiple marketing elements (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002).

At the same time, adaptation enhances relevance by allowing companies to tailor communication to specific market conditions, industries and customer needs. This aligns with the AdaptStand perspective (Vrontis, 2003), where companies combine global consistency with local responsiveness. As highlighted by Company C, adapting communication to different customer segments and stages in the customer journey is essential for maintaining relevance across markets.

However, the findings further indicate that these opportunities are also accompanied by significant challenges. A central insight is that the same mechanisms that enable efficiency and consistency may also be the factors that introduce complexity and reduce flexibility. For instance, Company C highlights how increased coordination requirements can lead to longer processes, unclear responsibilities and less impactful outcomes. This reflects the challenges identified by Ambos et al. (2010), where coordination across organizational levels can create inefficiencies and limit responsiveness in practice.

In addition, tensions between headquarters and local units emerge as a recurring challenge. Company E illustrates how differences in perspectives and market understanding can create tension, where local units may feel constrained in their ability

to adapt strategies while headquarters may not fully capture local market conditions. This highlights the difficulty of balancing centralized control with local responsiveness, and supports the view that coordination is not only structural but also shaped by relational dynamics and continuously negotiated over time (Poulis, 2024).

Furthermore, trade-offs between strategic consistency and local responsiveness become evident across the companies. While standardized structures support efficiency, alignment and brand coherence, they may simultaneously reduce the ability to respond quickly to local market needs. This is particularly visible in more organizationally complex companies, where decision-making processes become slower and require greater coordination across organizational levels. These findings reinforce the dynamic nature of international marketing strategy, where companies continuously adjust their strategic approaches in response to changing internal and external conditions (Solberg & Durrieu, 2023).

Another important insight concerns the role of resource availability in shaping these trade-offs. Company A illustrates how limited resources constrain the extent to which localized adaptation can be implemented, leading to stronger reliance on standardization. At the same time, Company B demonstrates that insufficient adaptation can reduce market relevance, suggesting that both extremes involve limitations. This view is supported by Vrontis et al. (2009), who argue that a purely standardized or fully adapted strategy is not sustainable in practice.

Lastly, the findings indicate that the effectiveness of hybrid approaches depends not only on the design of the strategy itself, but also on the organizational conditions under which it is implemented. In line with Homburg et al. (1999), the influence of marketing within the company and the degree of organizational alignment affect how effectively companies are able to manage competing priorities. Companies with stronger coordination structures and clearer strategic roles for marketing appear better positioned to balance efficiency and responsiveness, whereas companies with more limited capabilities face greater challenges in implementing an effective hybrid approach.

Overall, the findings indicate that hybrid approaches do not eliminate the tension between standardization and adaptation but rather shift it into an ongoing process of managing competing organizational and market-related priorities. While companies benefit from increased efficiency, consistency and scalability, they must simultaneously navigate coordination complexity, organizational constraints and varying local market demands. This highlights that international marketing strategy is not only about achieving a strategic balance, but also about continuously managing competing priorities across organizational levels and market contexts.

Based on the empirical findings and cross-case analysis, Table 3 summarizes the dominant drivers, organizational constraints and key strategic trade-offs identified across the interviewed companies.

*Table 3. Summary of dominant drivers, constraints and key strategic trade-offs across the interviewed companies.*

| **Company** | **Dominant Drivers** | **Main Constraint** | **Key Trade-offs** |
|---|---|---|---|
| A | Resource-oriented | Limited capacity | Efficiency vs Adaptation |
| B | Efficiency-oriented | Brand consistency | Scale vs local relevance |
| C | Coordination-oriented | Organizational complexity | Alignment vs speed |
| D | Brand-oriented | Market variations | Consistency vs flexibility |
| E | Market-oriented | Regulation | Local relevance vs standardization |

As illustrated in Table 3, the analysis indicates that the companies differ regarding which factors primarily shape their balance between standardization and adaptation. While some companies are mainly influenced by internal organizational conditions, such as resource availability and coordination structures, others are more strongly shaped by external market conditions, including regulation and customer-specific demands.

The findings further suggest that all companies experience ongoing strategic trade-offs between global consistency and local responsiveness, although these tensions emerge differently depending on the organizational context and internal capabilities.

## 5.5 Implications for the Framework

The findings support the proposed analytical framework while also suggesting several important refinements that improve its ability to explain how companies balance standardization and adaptation in practice.

First, the findings indicate that companies manage strategic balancing at the level of specific marketing elements rather than through a singular strategic choice. This suggests that the framework should more explicitly reflect a modular approach, where strategic and executional activities are managed differently across markets. Compared to the initial framework presented in Figure 2, this refinement provides a more detailed representation of how marketing activities are differentiated and coordinated in practice.

Second, the findings show that international marketing strategy is dynamic and evolves over time. Rather than representing a fixed strategic position, companies continuously adjust their approaches in response to changing internal organizational conditions and external market conditions. The framework therefore incorporates feedback loops and dynamic adjustment mechanisms to better capture how strategic balancing evolves through implementation, coordination and organizational learning.

Third, coordination emerges as a central mechanism shaping how international marketing strategies are implemented in practice but is not limited to formal structures alone. While mechanisms such as shared platforms and KPIs support alignment, the

findings highlight that coordination also occurs through continuous interaction and negotiation between headquarters and local units. This strengthens the view of alignment as an interactive and process-oriented concept (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002; Ambos et al., 2010), which is more explicitly reflected in the refined framework.

Fourth, the findings further highlight the importance of contextual differences in shaping strategic implementation. Even within relatively similar markets, variations in industry conditions, customer expectations and regulatory environments require companies to adapt marketing activities differently across markets. This suggests that the framework should more clearly reflect the interaction between external market conditions and internal organizational capabilities when explaining strategic balancing. Furthermore, these findings suggest that organizational capabilities should be viewed as a key component of international marketing strategy than previously emphasized. While existing frameworks acknowledge the importance of coordination and implementation (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002; Katsikeas et al., 2020), the findings indicate that factors such as organizational structure, resource availability and coordination capabilities actively shape how companies balance standardization and adaptation in practice. The refined framework highlights organizational capabilities as a key mechanism through which hybrid marketing strategies are implemented and maintained across markets.

By incorporating these refinements, the framework provides a more accurate representation of how Nordic B2B service companies manage international marketing strategies across markets. In particular, it captures how strategies are applied at the level of specific elements, continuously adjusted over time and implemented through a combination of formal coordination mechanisms and ongoing organizational interaction.

However, while the refined framework better reflects the empirical findings compared to the initial model presented in Figure 2, it remains a conceptual simplification of a highly dynamic process. The findings indicate that strategic balancing is continuously negotiated across organizational levels and shaped through the interaction between external market conditions and internal organizational dynamics. As such, the framework should be understood as a guiding analytical structure rather than a fixed representation of how international marketing strategies are implemented in practice.

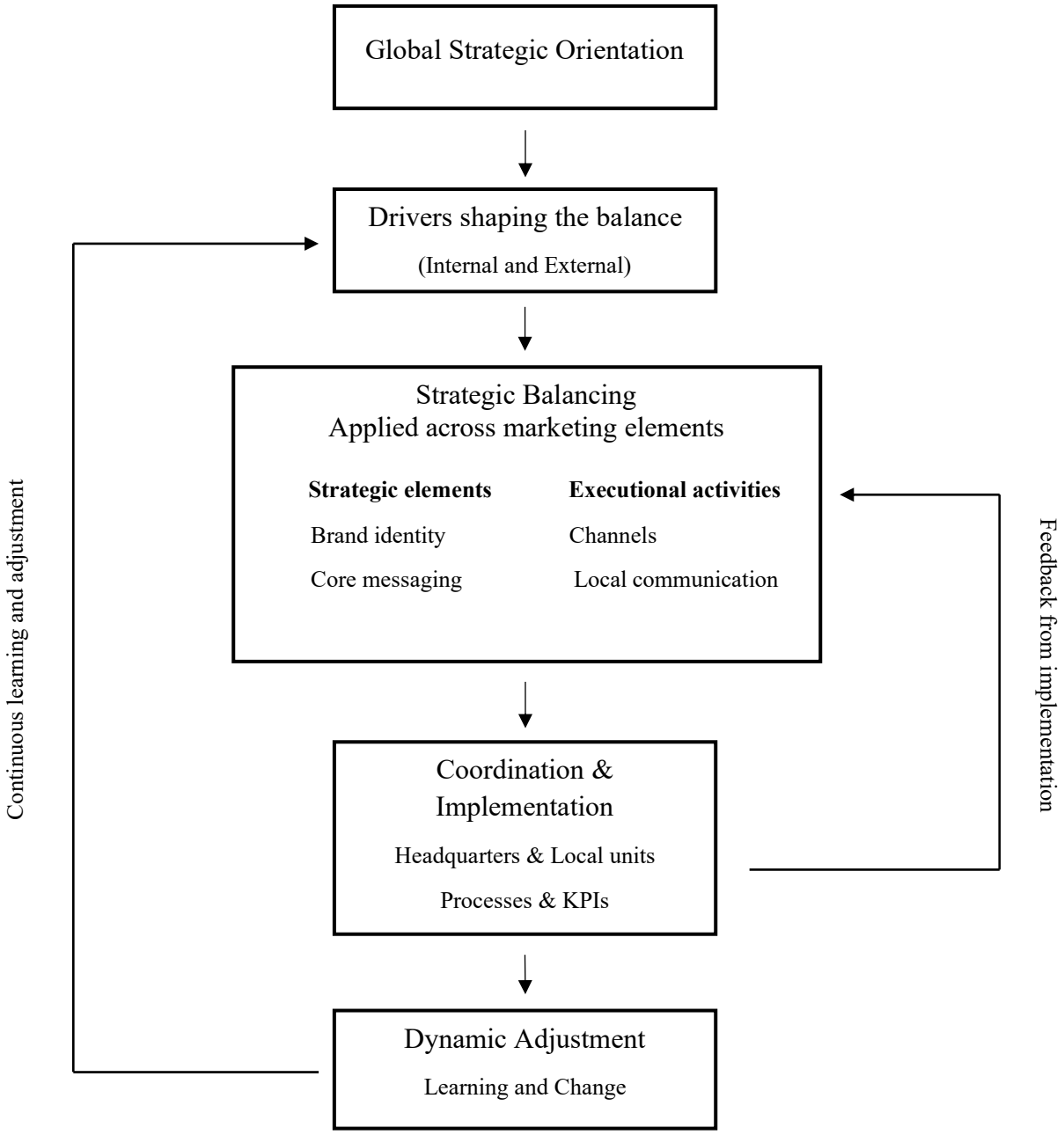



*Figure 3. Refined analytical framework of international marketing strategy balance*

# 6 Discussion

The findings of this study suggest that Nordic B2B service companies do not approach standardization and adaptation as separate strategic alternatives. Instead, companies combine both approaches by maintaining a standardized strategic core while adapting executional marketing activities to local market conditions. However, rather than reflecting a single strategic approach, the findings indicate that this balance is structured differently across companies depending on organizational conditions and market context.

While prior research has emphasized the coexistence of standardization and adaptation (Vrontis, 2003; Zou & Cavusgil, 2002), the findings suggest that existing literature tends to frame this balance as a strategic choice. In contrast, the results of this study indicate that in practice, the balance is often shaped by organizational capabilities and limitations, rather than solely by deliberate strategic intent. This suggests that international marketing strategy is not only a question of "what companies choose to do", but also a question of "what companies are able to do" given their internal conditions.

A central insight from the findings is that the balance between standardization and adaptation is managed at the level of specific marketing elements rather than as an overall strategic position. Strategic elements such as brand identity, positioning and value proposition are generally standardized to ensure consistency and efficiency, while executional activities such as campaigns, channels and customer communication are adapted to local conditions. This indicates that international marketing strategy may be less about defining a clear singular strategic position and more about how different marketing elements are connected in practice.

At the same time, the findings highlight that this separation between strategic consistency and operational flexibility does not come without challenges. While hybrid approaches create opportunities for efficiency and stronger brand consistency, several companies describe difficulties relating to coordination, unclear responsibilities and slower decision-making processes. This suggests that hybrid approaches involve managing competing strategic demands, where mechanisms intended to support alignment and efficiency may simultaneously reduce flexibility and responsiveness in local markets.

The findings further indicate that the relationship between standardization and adaptation is dynamic rather than static. Companies continuously adjust their strategies in response to changes in regulation, competition, customer expectations and internal organizational priorities. This strengthens more recent perspectives in international marketing literature, where strategic balancing is understood as an ongoing and evolving process rather than a one-time decision (Poulis, 2024). At the same time, the findings extend this perspective by showing that this process is shaped by the interaction between internal capabilities and external pressures.

Another important insight concerns the role of coordination between headquarters and local units. The findings suggest that alignment across markets is not only dependent on formal structures such as centralized processes and shared platforms, but also on continuous interaction and negotiation between organizational actors. Therefore, coordination emerges as both a structural and relational process, where centralized mechanisms support consistency and efficiency, while local market knowledge remains essential for ensuring relevance and responsiveness in execution. As such, organizational observations further indicated that coordination and interaction across organizational levels constituted an ongoing aspect of managing marketing activities across markets. The observations further highlighted how organizational structures, communication routines and decision-making processes influenced the implementation of marketing strategies, reinforcing the importance of internal capabilities in shaping strategic outcomes. This view challenges prior research by suggesting that coordination is not only structural but also shaped by relational dynamics in practice.

Furthermore, companies differ significantly in how hybrid approaches are operationalized, depending on organizational structure, resource availability and the degree of centralization. Companies with more centralized structures and limited resources tend to rely more heavily on standardized approaches, while companies with greater local presence and more developed marketing capabilities are better positioned to implement more extensive adaptation across markets. This challenges the assumption in prior research that hybrid approaches can be actively designed and implemented in a static way and instead suggests that companies operate within practical limitations that shape their strategic flexibility.

In addition, the findings highlight the characteristics that are particularly relevant in the context of Nordic B2B service companies. Compared to companies operating across more institutionally diverse markets, the Nordic region has relatively similar institutional environments which may reduce the need for extensive adaptation at a structural level. At the same time, the relationship-driven nature of service companies emphasizes the importance of customer relationships, context-specific communication and industry-specific knowledge which increases the need for flexibility in execution. This suggests that even within relatively similar markets, adaptation remains important but primarily occurs at the level of communication and customer interaction rather than in core strategic elements.

While previous research has largely examined standardization and adaptation across culturally and institutionally diverse markets, the findings indicate that adaptation remains important even within relatively similar Nordic market environments. This suggests that customer needs, communication relevance and organizational conditions may be as important as broader market differences in shaping international marketing strategies. By focusing specifically on Nordic B2B service companies, the study also extends existing knowledge to a context that has received limited empirical attention in previous research.

The findings also contribute to existing literature by extending current perspectives on standardization and adaptation. While previous research has focused on how companies balance standardization and adaptation as a strategic decision, the findings indicate that the implementation of this balance is strongly influence by organizational capabilities, resource availability and coordination structures. This suggests that the ability to realize a hybrid strategy depends not only on a strategic intent but also on organizational conditions that support or constrain adaptation in practice. In this regard, the study extends the AdaptStand perspective (Vrontis, 2003; Vrontis et al., 2009), the global marketing strategy framework (Zou & Cavusgil, 2002) and more recent process-oriented perspectives (Poulis, 2024) by highlining that the role of organizational conditions in shaping how international marketing strategies are implemented across markets.

Overall, the findings show that international marketing strategy is not only a strategic consideration, but also an organizational one. The ability to implement hybrid approaches depends on internal capabilities, coordination structures and resource availability, which shape how strategic intentions are translated into practice. This suggests that international marketing strategy is not simply about achieving strategic alignment, but also about continuously managing competing priorities across organizational levels and market contexts.

## 6.1 Theoretical implications

The findings contribute to existing literature on international marketing strategy in several ways.

First, the findings extend the traditional standardization versus adaptation discussion by demonstrating that strategic balancing is managed at the level of individual marketing elements rather than through a singular strategic orientation. While previous research has emphasized the coexistence of standardized and locally adapted approaches, this study provides further empirical insight into how Nordic B2B service companies operationalize hybrid marketing strategies in practice. In particular, the findings build upon the AdaptStand perspective introduced by Vrontis (2003) and Vrontis et al. (2009), by showing that companies selectively standardize strategic core elements while adapting executional activities in response to local market conditions. Furthermore, the study contributes by providing empirical insight into how Nordic B2B service companies manage this balance in practice. While previous research has often focused on culturally and institutionally diverse international markets, the findings suggest that adaptation remains important even within relatively similar Nordic market environments. The findings further suggest that the implementation of such hybrid strategies depends on organizational capabilities and resource-related constraints, thereby extending existing explanations of how the balance between standardization and adaptation is achieved in practice.

Second, the findings support and extend the view of international marketing strategy as a dynamic and evolving process (Poulis, 2024). Rather than representing a fixed strategic position, the balance between standardization and adaptation is continuously shaped through the interaction between organizational actors, market conditions and internal organizational capabilities. This highlights that international marketing strategy is not only dynamic over time but also contingent on the company's organizational ability to respond to changing market conditions.

Third, the study contributes to research on coordination and organizational alignment by demonstrating that the ability to balance standardization and adaptation is not purely dependent on strategic intent, but also on organizational capabilities and coordination structures. The findings show that internal organizational factors such as resource availability, organizational structure and marketing influence play a critical role in shaping strategic outcomes. This extends previous research (Homburg et al., 1999; Ambos et al., 2010) by illustrating how coordination mechanisms and internal capabilities influence the implementation of international marketing strategies across markets.

Overall, the findings contribute to a more nuanced understanding of international marketing strategy by highlighting how strategic balancing is shaped not only by external market conditions, but also by internal organizational capabilities, coordination structures and recourse-related constraints.

## 6.2 Managerial implications

The findings of this study provide several managerial implications for Nordic B2B service companies operating across multiple markets.

First, companies may benefit from maintaining a standardized strategic core while allowing flexibility in execution-related marketing activities. Standardizing elements such as brand identity, positioning and value proposition can strengthen consistency across markets. At the same time, local adaptation of campaigns and communication may improve market relevance and customer responsiveness. This suggests that companies should structure marketing activities at the level of specific elements rather than applying a single strategy across markets.

Second, the findings highlight the importance of coordination between headquarters and local units. Companies operating across multiple markets should therefore invest in structures and processes that support collaboration, communication and knowledge sharing across organizational levels. While centralized frameworks can create alignment and efficiency, local units remain important for providing market-specific insights and ensuring that marketing activities reflect local customer needs and market conditions.

Third, companies should ensure that roles and responsibilities between headquarters and local units are clearly defined. While hybrid approaches may be effective, they also increase the need for coordination and may create unclear decision-making structures, delays and internal tensions within the organization. Establishing clear structures can therefore support more effective implementation across markets.

Fourth, the findings indicate that companies need to consider internal capabilities and resource availability when designing effective international marketing strategies. The ability to implement local adaptation is often limited due to resource constraints, suggesting that companies should align their strategic ambitions with their operational capacity.

Finally, companies should view international marketing strategy as an ongoing balancing process rather than a fixed strategic decision. Continuous evaluation and adjustment of marketing activities may therefore be necessary to respond effectively to changing market conditions, customer needs and organizational priorities.

# 7 Conclusions

The purpose of this study was to explore how Nordic B2B service companies balance standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across multiple markets and to identify the strategic, organizational and contextual factors shaping this balance in practice.

In relation to this purpose, the study shows that Nordic B2B service companies do not approach standardization and adaptation as two separate strategic alternatives. Instead, all studied companies apply a hybrid approach where core strategic elements, such as brand identity, positioning and overall messaging, are largely standardized, while marketing activities and customer-facing communication are adapted to local market conditions.

Regarding the first research question, concerning how Nordic B2B service companies approach the balance between standardization and adaptation, the findings demonstrate that companies combine both approaches simultaneously rather than choosing one over the other. The balance varies depending on organizational conditions, market characteristics and the type of marketing element. While strategic core elements are generally standardized to ensure consistency and efficiency, local adaptation is primarily applied in customer-facing activities and executional processes in order to increase relevance within specific markets.

Regarding the second research question, concerning how internal and external factors influence the balance between standardization and adaptation, the study shows that both external and internal factors shape strategic marketing decisions across markets. External factors such as market maturity, regulation, customer expectations and competitive conditions influence the need for local adaptation, while internal factors including organizational structure, resource availability and strategic priorities affect how companies manage and implement marketing strategies in practice. The findings further indicate that companies continuously evaluate these conditions when determining the appropriate balance between efficiency and local responsiveness.

Regarding the third research question, concerning how standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies are coordinated and managed across headquarters and local units, the findings show that coordination plays a central role in managing international marketing strategies. Companies rely on a combination of centralized strategic governance and local market knowledge, where alignment is achieved through shared frameworks, communication routines and continuous collaboration across organizational levels. At the same time, the findings indicate that more complex organizational structures often create challenges related to coordination, speed and decision-making processes.

The study further highlights that the balance between standardization and adaptation is dynamic, rather than fixed. The companies continuously adjust their strategic

approaches depending on contextual conditions, organizational capabilities and changing market demands. This suggests that international marketing strategy should not only be understood as a strategic choice, but also as an organizational and managerial process shaped by ongoing interaction between headquarters and local markets.

Overall, in relation to the purpose of the study, the findings provide insights into how Nordic B2B service companies manage international marketing strategies across multiple markets by balancing efficiency, consistency and local responsiveness through ongoing coordination and adaptation processes. The study contributes to existing international marketing literature by demonstrating that the balance between standardization and adaptation is not only shaped by strategic choices and market conditions, but also by organizational capabilities, coordination structures and resource constraints. Furthermore, the findings show that adaptation remains important even within relatively similar Nordic market environments, suggesting that customer needs, communication relevance and organizational conditions play a central role in shaping international marketing strategies in practice.

# 8 Limitations

This study has several limitations that should be acknowledged. First, the study is limited to Nordic B2B service companies, meaning that the findings are shaped by the specific institutional, cultural and organizational conditions of the Nordic context. As a result, the findings may not be fully transferable to companies operating in other regions or industries.

Second, the study applies a qualitative research design based on a relatively small sample of five companies and seven respondents. While this enabled an in-depth understanding of organizational perspectives and strategic processes, it limits the transferability of the findings.

In addition, the study focuses exclusively on B2B service firms, meaning that the findings may differ in product-oriented industries or B2C contexts where market dynamics and customer relationships can vary significantly.

Another limitation concerns the level of contextual detail that could be presented. Since the participating companies and respondents were anonymized, certain organizational details and contextual factors could not be presented in full detail.

Lastly, the study relies on interview-based empirical data, which means that the findings are based on respondents' interpretations and descriptions of organizational practices. This creates a potential risk of interview bias and socially desirable responses.

Despite these limitations, the study provides relevant insights into how Nordic B2B service companies manage the balance between standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across different markets.

# 9 Further research

Future research could further examine how the balance between standardization and adaptation evolves over time through longitudinal studies, particularly in relation to organizational development and changing market conditions. This would complement the dynamic perspective emphasized by Vrontis et al. (2009) and Poulis (2024).

In addition, comparative studies across regions outside the Nordic context could contribute to a broader understanding of how institutional and cultural differences influence international marketing strategies, extending the work of Rao-Nicholson and Khan (2017).

Future research could also explore how AI-driven marketing technologies and digital coordination mechanisms affect the relationship between headquarters and local units in multinational firms. Such studies could further develop the coordination perspectives presented by Zou and Cavusgil (2002) and Lee and Griffith (2019).

Another relevant direction would be to compare how small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) and multinational corporations (MNCs) manage standardization and adaptation differently depending on organizational structure, resources and international experience.

Finally, future studies could investigate how digitalization and integrated communication systems influence cross-market alignment and implementation processes in international B2B marketing contexts.

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# 11 Appendix 1: Interview guide

The following interview guide was used to structure the semi-structured interviews conducted in this study. The questions were designed to explore how Nordic B2B service companies balance standardized and locally adapted marketing strategies across markets.

1. Company background and market presence

- In which markets do your company operate?
- How would you describe your company's presence across Nordic and International markets?

2. Marketing strategy and organization

- How do your currently work with marketing across markets, from brand building to sales?
- Where are strategic and operational decisions made (e.g headquarters vs local units)?

3. Standardization vs Adaptation (Strategic Focus)

- How would you describe your current approach in terms of standardization and adaptation?
- How do you decide which elements of your marketing strategy are standardized and which are adapted locally?
- What factors influence this balance across different markets?
- Who is responsible for these decisions?
- What opportunities or strengths do you see with your current approach?
- What challenges do you experience?
- Are there aspects you would like to change? Why?

4. Implementation and Communication

- How do you decide which elements of communication should remain consistent and which should be adapted locally?

5.

- How are decisions distributed between headquarters and local market units?
- How do you ensure alignment between strategy and local implementation?
- How does the balance between standardization and adaptation evolve over time?